Understanding the intersecting barriers that people with learning disabilities encounter when trying to access higher education

Research Dossier

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Chapter 1

Literature Review

Alberta Human Rights Commission. (2021). *Duty to accommodate students with disabilities in post-secondary educational institutions*. https://albertahumanrights.ab.ca/Documents/Bull_Duty_to_accom_students.pdf

This source was important to my research because it provided the legal requirements of university institutions to accommodate students with disabilities. It states, "The Supreme Court of Canada has ruled that where the educational environment has a discriminatory effect on students with disabilities, the post-secondary institution is required to provide accommodation up to the point of undue hardship" (p. 8). This shows that there are legal protections in place for students with disabilities by the supreme court. Additionally, it provides recommendations for how institutions can implement inclusive practices into their universities.

Arim, R. & Frenette, M. (2019). Are mental health and neurodevelopmental conditions barriers to postsecondary access?. *Analytical Studies Branch Research Paper Series*, 11F0019M No. 417. https://www150.statcan.gc.ca/n1/pub/11f0019m/11f0019m2019005-eng.htm

This resource from Statistics Canada provides quantitative data to show the gap between people with neurodevelopmental conditions (NDC) and/or mental health conditions (MHC), and accessing post-secondary education (PSE). This data helps to conceptualize the barriers that exist for people with disabilities to access PSE. For example, in the article, Arim & Frenette (2019) state, "77% of youth in the comparison group enrolled in PSE by their early 20s. In contrast, 60% of youth diagnosed with an NDC enrolled in PSE in the same time frame... while only 48% of youth diagnosed with an MHC enrolled in postsecondary... Youth diagnosed with both an NDC and an MHC were even less likely to enroll: only 36% went on to PSE". This shows that the rates of enrolment in post-secondary education, in comparison to people without NDCs or MHCs (77%), is significantly higher than the rates of enrollment when compared to people with either a NDC, MHC, or both. These findings reassured my suspicions that there was a gap in enrollment, but helps frame the issue using statistics.

Bunbury, S. (2020). Disability in higher education—Do reasonable adjustments contribute to an inclusive curriculum? *International Journal of Inclusive Education*, 24(9), 964–979. https://doi.org/10.1080/13603116.2018.1503347

This source was good for framing the issue and some of the underlying reasons why students struggle once they are in higher education. For example, Bunbury (2020) states, "staff struggle to accommodate disabled students, due to a lack of knowledge, training and awareness of disability" (p. 964). This shows the importance of creating training methods targeted towards professors to help try and bridge the gap between learning methods and the needs of students. This source is a part of the learning stream of my project, which focuses on how the style of teaching also creates barriers for people with learning disabilities.

Canadian Human Rights Commission. (2017). *Left out: Challenges faced by persons with disabilities in Canada's schools* (Report No. 978-0-660-07398-9). Canadian Human Rights Commission. https://publications.gc.ca/collections/collection_2017/ccdp-chrc/HR4-41-2017-eng.pdf

This source was key to the research completed, as it provides barriers to education for people with disabilities, as well as statistics about completion rates for people with disabilities. For example, some of the barriers discussed are: lack of disability accommodation and support, lack of services and funding, ineffective dispute resolution mechanisms, and lack of special education and disability supports on First Nations reserves. Additionally, a key finding of this report was that 10% of people with disabilities across Canada stopped their education altogether because of their disability.

Carroll, J. M., Pattison, E., Muller, C., & Sutton, A. (2020). Barriers to bachelor's degree completion among college students with a disability. *Sociological Perspectives*, 63(5), 809–832. https://doi.org/10.1177/0731121420908896

This source was found after my subject-matter expert interview with Carola Tiltmann. It was significant to my research as it confirmed that people with disabilities often take longer to complete their studies. For example, Carroll et al. (2020) states, "students with a mental disability are more likely to fail or withdraw from courses in their first-year of college, to lower their educational expectations, and to stop-out or transfer than their peers without a disability". This shows that there is significant challenges for students with disabilities in adjusting to post-secondary education.

CERIC. (2019, May 10). *Post-secondary students with disabilities face gaps in career education services*. https://ceric.ca/2019/05/post-secondary-students-with-disabilities-face-gaps-in-career-education-services/

This source was important because it provides insight into what students with disabilities plan on doing after post-secondary school. For example, CERIC (2019) states, "Approximately 60% of graduating students with disabilities plan to continue with further education or career development after graduation, with 38% expected to apply to graduate school and 22% expected to apply to professional school". Additionally, it provides information on the work placement rates for students with disabilities after graduation. For example, it states, "Thirty-one percent of students with disabilities say they have employment arranged for after graduation" (CERIC, 2019).

Dirth, T. P., & Branscombe, N. R. (2017). Disability Models Affect Disability Policy Support through Awareness of Structural Discrimination. *Journal of Social Issues*, 73(2), 413–442. https://doi.org/10.1111/josi.12224

This article goes over the Social and Medical Models of disability. Understanding models of disability theory is crucial to do this type of research, as it provides a framework for looking at disability. My research focuses on the social model of disability, which looks at the barriers that disabled people face as a result of their disability. This is significant, as looking at disability from the social model would help with creating an inclusive classroom environment. For example, Dirth & Branscombe (2017) state, "a social model opens new possibilities for engagement with disability both in the classroom and in the community. This model accentuates the need for greater community support of people with diverse physical and mental abilities, and pushes back against popular narratives of disability as tragic, inferior, and incapable of contributing meaningfully" (p. 433). This shows that more social support is needed, rather than looking at disability on the individual level, like the medical model, which is more in line with the practices currently at universities, such as accommodation-based accessibility services.

Dolmage, J. (2018). *Academic ableism disability and higher education*. Project Muse.

This book made me shift my view in how I looked at higher education, and seeing even the societal expectations to get higher education as an ableist viewpoint due to the many barriers that prevent people with disabilities to pursue post-secondary education. The chapter of this book titled "Steep Steps" was used to identify the ways in which post-secondary institutions gatekeep and prevent people with disabilities from accessing higher education. Whether intentional or not, the systems in place for these institutions make it very difficult for people with disabilities to access post-secondary education.

***Exploring challenges to accessing post-secondary education for at-risk youth/young adults* (No. 9780660294629). (2019). desLibris; Canada Commons. https://canadacommons.ca/artifacts/1203778/exploring-challenges-to-accessing-post-secondary-education-for-at-risk-youthyoung-adults/**

This article unpacks some of the various reasons why at-risk people do not pursue post-secondary education, or some of the barriers that they face when they enter post-secondary. For an example, it states, "A few participants with disabilities said they did not consider pursuing post-secondary education because they do not have the skills and aptitudes necessary to succeed at the post-secondary level, given the nature of their disability" (p. 10). This shows that there is a barrier at preparing people with disabilities in preparing them for post-secondary education before they even start it. This impacts their decision to not pursue a post-secondary education. Additionally, this source goes over financial barriers that people with disabilities face when funding their education (p. 19). However, this paper states that financial barriers are not the only reason why some people with disabilities do not pursue post-secondary education. Additionally, there are academic barriers for people with disabilities to access higher education (p. 31).

Fields, A., Bourbeau, E., & Patterson, M. (2018). Annual review of the labour market, 2017. *Labour Statistics: Research Papers*, 75-004-M. https://www150.statcan.gc.ca/n1/pub/75-004-m/75-004-m2018001-eng.htm

This source was used to compare the national unemployment rates to the unemployment rates found in people with disabilities (See Statistics Canada, 2017). This was key to my research because it provided a tangible example of why it is so important to address this problem, as there are much higher rates of unemployment for people with disabilities.

Gray, S. A., Fettes, P., Woltering, S., Mawjee, K., & Tannock, R. (2016). Symptom manifestation and impairments in college students with ADHD. *Journal of Learning Disabilities*, 49(6), 616–630. https://doi.org/10.1177/0022219415576523

This study was an important part of my research, as it refuted preconceived notions that I had about academic performance for people with ADHD in post-secondary. It states, "Students' self-reported GPAs fell in the acceptable- to-good range, as has been reported in other studies (e.g., Sparks et al., 2004), and they did not display impairment in fluent performance of basic academic skills (word reading, math fluency)" (Gray et al., 2016, p. 626). I was under the impression that GPAs would be negatively affected by ADHD. Although this study notes that half the participants were medicated and some had accommodations in their institutions, I still thought there would be negative impacts on a student's GPA.

Gyenes, J., & Siegel, L. S. (2014). A Canada-wide examination of the criteria employed for learning disability documentation in English speaking postsecondary institutions. *Canadian Journal of School Psychology*, 29(4), 279–295. Canadian Business & Current Affairs Database.

This article examined the barriers in which people with disabilities face barriers to receiving their accommodations. For example, Gyenes & Siegel (2014) state:

> "Canadian postsecondary students with LD... encounter a bewildering variety of, and at times conflicting LD documentation requirements. To avoid the possibility of allegations of indirect discrimination with regard to academic accommodation provisions, accessibility/disability personnel and provincial ministries of adult/higher education need common criteria for acceptable LD documentation" (p. 292).

This shows that there is a need for standardized practices across all universities in Canada to access accommodations, so they don't need to face additional barriers when accessing these services. Additionally, some people with disabilities may only have the funds to visit the doctor once, if at all, to receive this documentation so if they need to go multiple times, it poses a financial barrier as well.

Hindes, Y., & Mather, J. (2007). Inclusive education at the post-secondary level: Attitudes of students and professors. *Exceptionality Education Canada*, 17(1,2), 107.

This study examines the ways in which disability is viewed in the classroom. Although this source is quite dated, it still provided valuable insight into the ways in which disabilities are stigmatized within the classroom. For example, Hindes & Mather (2007) state:

> "Attitudes towards the inclusion of individuals with disabilities are influenced by the type of disability as well as by the extent of inclusion. This finding is clearly indicated by the more negative attitudes towards psychiatric and attention disabilities and by the more negative attitudes towards providing professorial accommodations and assistance. Educators in general appear to be more willing to include students with disabilities that are perceived to be mild than those with disabilities perceived as severe and problematic in classes" (p. 117).

This shows that there are a number of factors that play a role into the levels of barriers that people with disabilities face, depending on what the disability is.

Hutcheon, E. J., & Wolbring, G. (2012). Voices of "disabled" post secondary students: Examining higher education "disability" policy using an ableism lens. *Journal of Diversity in Higher Education*, 5(1), 39–49. APA PsycArticles. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0027002

This source provides a local example of how disability impacts the educational experiences of people when accessing post-secondary education. This source was published by the University of Calgary, using participants from Alberta. The findings suggest that the current model of looking at disability within post-secondary education provides additional barriers for people with disabilities. For example, Hutcheon & Wolbring (2012) state:

> "the university's response to difference becomes individualized (thus disregarding other sources of disablement, including attitudinal barriers, barriers caused by institutional structure, and others). Further, the presumption of disability as biomedical in nature tends to shape the process such that "evidence" of disability on an individual/biomedical/psychological level (e.g., documentation of diagnosis) is required to receive services. This is problematic for individuals who cannot afford the required medical assessments, or whose ability-difference is consequential for their learning but unrecognized by the medical community (Devlin & Pothier, 2006)" (p. 46).

This shows that the current way of framing disability in post-secondary education, using accommodations, is somewhat ableist. This source also provides other examples of how ableism manifests itself in post-secondary education.

LDAOeng. (2015, February 18). *Learning Disabilities and Mental Health*. LD@school. https://www.ldatschool.ca/learning-disabilities-and-mental-health/

This source was found after my SME interview with Carola Tiltmann to see the link between learning disabilities and mental health. It was significant to my research, as it shows the ways in which people with learning disabilities are at higher risk of mental health issues. As such, it is important to address mental health in my research and how it impacts a person's ability to complete their post-secondary education.

Mou, M., & Albagmi, F. M. (2021). Critical discourse analysis of federal and provincial government grants for post-secondary students with disabilities in Alberta and Ontario. *Disability & Society*, 1–29. https://doi.org/10.1080/09687599.2021.1983418

This source was used for the funding stream of my research, as it goes over the model for grants available to people with disabilities in Alberta and Ontario. For example, Mou and Albagmi (2021) state, "this study has shed light to the 'mismatch' between the realities of government disability grants and the view people have of this reality that functions ideologically. Instead, students are left with more responsibilities to prove their worthiness for assistance, without knowing for certain whether they will receive necessary funds in a capitalistic world that heavily favours the normalized 'able" (p. 26). This shows that the funding that is available is not enough to support people with disabilities and creates more "hoops" for them to jump through in order to access the funding.

Mullins, L., & Preyde, M. (2013). The lived experience of students with an invisible disability at a Canadian university. *Disability & Society*, 28(2), 147–160. https://doi.org/10.1080/09687599.2012.752127

This source was crucial to include in my research, as it includes the lived experiences of people with disabilities, which is a research blindspot for so many existing papers on this topic. It shares stories of the barriers that people with disabilities have faced in their post-secondary education. Additionally, they provide recommendations for making post-secondary education more inclusive for students with invisible disabilities such as ADHD, dyslexia, and other mental health disorders.

National Educational Association of Disabled Students. (2018). *Landscape of accessibility and accommodation in post-secondary education for students with disabilities*. https://www.neads.ca/en/about/media/AccessibilityandAccommodation%202018-5landscapereport.pdf

This 154-page report was helpful for my research for a number of reasons. For starters, it provides many recommendations for improving post-secondary education for people with disabilities, such as legislative, provincial and federal government, institutional, community agencies/professional societies, transition, technology in education, and further research recommendations. In total, these 95 recommendations helped me focus the areas that I researched for this project. Additionally, it identified barriers for people with disabilities to access post-secondary education, critiqued the accommodation model of post-secondary education, and discusses cognitive overload for people with disabilities (a concept that was new in my research findings that helped me look into mental health of people with disabilities in their post-secondary education).

Prince, M. J. (2016). Inclusive employment for Canadians with disabilities: Toward a new policy framework and agenda. In *IRPP Study* (1822923135; p. 0_1,1-23,25). Institute for Research on Public Policy; Canadian Business & Current Affairs Database. http://libproxy.mtroyal.ca/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/reports/inclusive-employment-canadians-with-disabilities/docview/1822923135/se-2?accountid=1343

This paper provides plenty of insights for improving employment opportunities for people with disabilities. However, the section of this paper that provided the most relevant information for this research was the "Expand post-secondary education" section (p. 16-17). This was one of the 6 components for a new policy framework for expanding employment opportunities for people with disabilities. It touches on the role both the federal and provincial governments have on making inclusive post-secondary opportunities available For example, Prince (2016) states, "The Council of Ministers of Education should identify students with disabilities and post-secondary education as a new priority. Ministers should focus on students' transitions from secondary schools to post-secondary institutions; make financial assistance available to students with disabilities; and examine best practices on work accommodation and inclusive education at colleges and universities" (p. 17). This quote in particular made me examine the role that the government plays in creating inclusive policies for people with disabilities.

Public Health Agency of Canada (2021, March 29). *Infographic: Developmental disabilities or disorders in Canada* - Highlights from the 2017 Canadian survey on disability. https://www.canada.ca/en/public-health/services/publications/diseases-conditions/infographic-developmental-disabilities-disorder-highlights-canadian-survey-2017.html#shr-pg0

This source was relevant to my research, as it provides various metrics for looking at how disability impacts the lives of those living with it. For example, it states, "43% report having less than high school education, compared to 12% without disability". This shows that there is a need for more supports for people with disabilities to access education in order to complete their studies. It also made me look into the reasons why people with disabilities drop out of school, some of the explanations are found in Canadian Human Rights Commission (2017).

Statistics Canada, (2017, April 7). *Labour force status for adults with disabilities by disability type*. https://www150.statcan.gc.ca/t1/tbl1/en/tv.action?pid=1310034801

This source was used as it provides unemployment statistics for the different types of disabilities. This was important to my research, as I was able to compare it to the unemployment rates found in the general population. For example, the unemployment rate for people with a learning disability was 21.1%, compared to the national unemployment rate at 6.3% in the same year (see Fields et al. 2018). This is one measure of showing why this is a problem that people should be aware of, and helps frame the issue.

Walcot-Gayda, E. (n.d.). *Understanding learning disabilities. Learning Disabilities Association of Canada* (LDAC). www.ldac-acta.ca/understanding-learning-disabilities

This source provides information on how learning disabilities affect students while they are in school. For example, if someone has an impairment in attention, their work may be disorganized, or they may go off on tangents. This type of information is important for my project, as it shows the implications of having a learning disability in the classroom. Additionally, it provides information on how different "impairments" affect a learner specifically in post-secondary. It also gives examples of how it can affect their lives outside the classroom, such as difficulty being a roommate and difficulty with direction on campus.

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Chapter 2

Subject-Matter Expert Interviews

Janet Arnold

Academic Advisor and Professor at Mount Royal University

Why is accessibility important to you? What inspired you to get into your role?

Having a lifetime of mental illness, kind of started out in junior high, and how that impacted my learning and when I was in university, didn't get a whole lot of support. Coming here, I worked in counselling first, so I was exposed to lots of students that have lots of challenges to learning. A position opened here, I was actually invited to apply because of my mental health background and the work I have done in that. I applied because I know how valuable accommodations are to students, and it helps them be successful. It's not a guarantee of success, but it gives students with different barriers more of an equal playing field. I think it's been so incredibly inspiring, seeing students who have had any kind of support all through school, because they didn't have a diagnosis. They get here, a professor recognizes something is going on, they refer to us, we do this whole process, eventually get they tested, so they usually will have a diagnosis. Then to see what a difference that makes to their schooling and even to their own self-esteem and sense of power because they've grown up thinking, "I'm dumb" or "I work so much harder than everyone else and my marks don't show it". Once they recognize this isn't their fault, this is a condition they have that impacts their learning, a lot of them are like, "Oh my goodness, I'm really not dumb, it's this issue that's creating problems". Once we address this issue and give them the supports to help mitigate the barriers they have, their marks just go sky-high a lot of the time. It's about giving them the opportunity to see them be successful and blossom when maybe they never thought they could before. It's about giving students a chance to show what they know and learn what they need to learn.

What is Universal Design for Learning (UDL)?

Universal Design actually started as an element of architecture, so how do we make builds more accessible to people who have a variety of different needs? So when it became into the learning environment, it really is about teaching in a way that will benefit all students in a class. Whoever is there, you structure how you teach, how you assess, and how you interact with your students in a way that will meet as many people's needs as possible, without having to have accommodation. It's like a global way of giving access to the most students possible, no matter how they learn or what their barriers might be. Universal design actually helps everybody, not just students with disabilities.

What is the difference between accommodation based accessibility and UDL at universities? What are the advantages and/or disadvantages of each?

If all universities practiced UDL, there probably would not be a need for accessibility. The challenge with

accessibility is forcing students to meet particular criteria to have a specific diagnosis. It may be mental health, ADHD or a physical disability, whether temporary or permanent. We still need to have documentation of this. There are a lot of physicians that will charge for this documentation. There are many physicians where the student thinks they have ADHD, but the doctor says they are not skilled enough to diagnose that. Then we have to go through our process, which can take months sometimes. In the meantime, the student is not getting what they need, because we do not have the label. So that's the problem with accommodation based accessibility, in a way it creates more barriers for students, because we say they have to have a diagnosis with documentation that shows you have this. I think the other concern we have as a team is that sometimes there is a lot of stigma attached. Students may feel that they don't want to be labeled, or they don't way to be different than their classmates. Their classmates may notice that they are not writing the test with the rest of the class. They notice that a student is missing, and that makes them "different" from everyone else, so they might not want to get that label. Whereas universal design, you don't need any of that. I use universal design in my class on many levels, I could always get better, but the thing is, start some place. I think students really appreciate that.

The advantage of UDL is you are meeting the needs of a wider variety of students by how you teach and how you assess. As a professor, you have to think more deeply about "why am I doing an assessment this way, can't I do it some other way?" I have an essay in my class, but I say to students, you can write something, but you can also do a poster. I've had 2 students do that as a song that meets the needs of the assessment. It is the outliers that are getting creative, and I think they have been taught in school that you have to write a paper, so that's where students are more comfortable. They are certainly taking a risk if they do something like a song, play or a video.

A disadvantage of UDL is that some students may not be comfortable outside the typical academic box, so they don't take those risks. It could partly be because they have been punished for doing risks in the past in their academic history.

The barrier to accessibility accommodations is that you have to go through this whole rigmarole to prove it, extra steps to let your professors know, negotiate with them how these accommodations are going to fit within the design of a particular class, having to book exams where other students don't. There are more steps involved in the academic accommodation process, plus the stigma. The advantage of accommodations is that it is leveling the playing field for students that were previously disadvantaged.

Since a large amount of people go undiagnosed with learning disabilities, how would UDL help combat this problem, in your opinion?

It really takes away the disability in a lot of cases, it depends on what the barrier is. I do double time for all of my students when writing exams, so those that may have slower processing or have to think or read things many times, they have the time that they need to do that. Students that have test anxiety, which we do not accommodate for, those students would have the time to write their test if they get anxious and have to take a break, they have time to do that and still complete the exam, I think it just benefits everyone. As a teacher here, when I learned about UDL, it really made me think about, why am I doing it this way? Why am I teaching

this way? Is there another way? I have lots of videos, I have diagrams, I have the words on the presentations, but then I have a visual of that as well because some students are more visual. All the videos that I post, I try and select only those that have the captions, because I have trouble hearing. Not everyone does, but if you have the words up there with the video, that helps everybody. If the person beside them is talking too loud or eating too loud, they can still see what the video is saying. Knowing that I am giving students choice in how they complete things and giving them options, to me that empowers them. They are more interested in the assignment, because it's something they designed. We all know what the purpose of the assignment is, and here are some guidelines, but if you want to do it a different way, just talk to me first, so we make sure you meet the criteria that are a part of why I have this assignment.

Do you have any final remarks?

There are advantages to all aspects of the learning, both to the teacher and to the students. Quite often when teachers are learning about this, their initial thought, and mine was too, how much extra work is this going to be? I think we have to allow and encourage all sides, the students and the faculty. This benefits everybody, it's not that hard, it's not going to be perfect, but open your mind to little elements. Do extra time for everybody, how fast you complete an exam is almost silly in the real world. Unless you are in something like nursing or aviation that needs to be time limited, quite typically in the workforce they have some time to do things, and they just need to know where to find the information. That is so much easier now than when I was in university, we didn't have computers and phones. Learning has changed, now it is about if the student know where to find the information they need to complete the task that they are supposed to complete. If we normalize it, and say this is a good thing for everybody, I think the world would be a better place, and you wouldn't be stigmatizing students or having them jump through certain hoops to get the support that they need.

The language that we use in teaching, is something that a lot of faculty may not consider. The class that I teach, when I am talking about myself, I will say my partner or their guardian, and try and make it as inclusive as possible there. I have deliberately gone through my exams and used names from different cultures. It is a small step, but it is important because we have students from many cultures and countries here. The least I can do is having them be able to see some names of their friends or their colleagues in their test paper.

Key Takeaways

Universal Design for Learning (UDL)

Universal design for learning is a means of alleviating some of the burden that students with disability face, such as having to get an official diagnosis, which in and of itself has many barriers. However, this can not be seen as a solution for the barriers that people with disabilities face when accessing post-secondary education. As seen in the literature review and other interviews, there are many other factors, such as financial barriers, grades in high school and mental health that impact people with disabilities in even making it to university. Suggesting that UDL is a solution would be under the assumption that people with disabilities are not at a disadvantage before getting to university.

Additionally, UDL is not a standardized practice, and is certainly not a “one size fits all” approach. The implementation of UDL in the classroom entirely relies on the individual level, the professor, and how they choose to implement that in their classroom. Some professors may start with giving extra time on exams, as Janet Arnold suggests, and stop there. Whereas other professors may go the extra step in ensuring other UDL approaches are also implemented. Even if UDL was perfectly implemented by every professor, there would still likely be a need for certain accommodations for people with disabilities to get access to in order to support their learning. This was significant to my research process as I thought I had found a solution for the problem, when in fact there were many other factors that were not considered initially in my research that arose from other interviews, my fieldwork and the research that is out there.

Inclusive Language

The importance of using inclusive language is highlighted in this interview. This approach has been used throughout this report, using people-first language, such as a person with a disability. The language used to address sensitive topics must be inclusive and not alienate groups that already face barriers in society. This research is meant to highlight these barriers and help support students with a learning disability, not try and bring them down.

Alternative Methods of Learning

For many people with disabilities, it is not that they cant learn, it is that they methods in which they learn do not fit inside of the “conventional” ways of learning. This shows that special consideration for how people with disabilities learn is important.

How the Workforce Has Changed

With the use of technology in the workforce, the ways in which we access information has changed drastically. Janet Arnold states, “How fast you complete an exam is almost silly in the real world. Unless you are in something like nursing or aviation that needs to be time limited, quite typically in the workforce they have some time to do things, and they just need to know where to find the information”. This shows that in many cases even the methods in which students are assessed do not line up with how the workforce really is. This was significant to my topic, as it shows that the means in which students with disabilities are assessed are not in line with what they will face in the workforce. It is often the case that students with learning disabilities will require more time to complete an exam. Looking at why exams are still a standard practice in post-secondary education sows that students with a disability are disadvantaged by this practice.

Carola Tiltmann

Manager - Learning Disabilities & ADHD Network (Calgary Region)

What is your role with learning disabilities and ADHD network and what does it entail?

I am the manager of the LD and ADHD network. That means I coordinate the activities of all members and the members are all volunteers. They're professionals, educators, psychologists, and researchers at the universities. And they just have a passion for people with learning disabilities and ADHD and making sure that there are as few barriers and many resources as possible for them. I coordinate those activities and we have action teams in those action teams looking to specific issues and come up with resources and solutions. And then additionally, I act as a resource navigator. When people write into the network or they call me, they have questions, then I help guide them to those resources or give them advice.

What type of barriers do people with learning disabilities or ADHD face before they go to post-secondary?

All right. I wrote myself a big list, so I would think the first one is personal in the sense that a lot of kids with learning disabilities and ADHD don't feel particularly smart. They think they're too stupid to go on to post-secondary. That will mainly come from the school experience they've had, especially if they've been diagnosed late or not diagnosed at all. School can be quite difficult for them. And especially in elementary, they've had a lot of messages about, why can't you do this? Or, you should try harder or do it this way, or why aren't you paying attention? Or, if you only focus more until we try it harder. A lot of very negative messaging about their abilities. Of course they have a learning disability, which really just means that they learn differently, not that they can't learn, but if you're constantly being presented information in a way that your brain doesn't process well and then you're constantly being asked to do things you don't understand very well how to do. You're not going to think you're very smart, right? Once children get diagnosed it can often be super helpful. But then again, it can still be difficult because a lot of teachers and school administrators obviously don't know a lot about learning disabilities or ADHD. Now just because you have a diagnosis doesn't mean it's straight sailing. Parents have to really step up and educate themselves about learning disabilities and ADHD in order that they can then advocate for their children at school. It can still be quite an uphill battle. How well teachers implement the accommodations in a class can also be really variable. So, you know, school tends to be a much more difficult for children that have elders and ADHD. And so apart from the fact even if they don't think they're stupid anymore, school is more difficult. It's harder for them than it is for other students a lot of the time. And then I would say that that's the second main reason. Like why would they go on to post-secondary, which everyone knows is more difficult than regular high school? If regular school is already so difficult, it's like punishing yourself. I would say those are

the two really big ones. They either think they're too stupid to go on or they think it's going to be so difficult that they're not going to make it. So, though, those are two really big ones, sort of their prior school experience. Then even if they don't think that they're stupid and they do think they can do university, there's still a perceived lack of skills in terms of transitioning from high school to post-secondary. So, it can be difficult to write. They think they're going to be able to do it, but they don't know if there's enough of a support network there at school. If the parents have been doing a lot of the advocating, they know that they're not going to be able to do that at university. Right. Once you're a teen, you're 18, you're an adult. You're going to have to do that all for yourself. And so it often feels like there's a layer of support that falls away once you go to post-secondary. Of course, your parents are still there and of course, they're still going to support you as much as you can, but they're not going to be the ones going into university, right? They're not going to be the ones talking to the professors the same way they might have come in to talk to the teachers when you were in K to 12. So, there there's a perception that there's a whole level of support that might now be missing, which can be scary then. I think for quite a few of the kids, there's just a lack of direction in their life after they finish high school. They just don't know what they're going to do because a school's been quite difficult, then they may not have a clear idea at all of what career path they want to follow, or they might have an idea of a career path and then just think it's far too difficult. They're kind of just floundering and that would be another reason to not go on to post-secondary right away is just don't know what they're going to do, what program they would pursue.

What kind of barriers to people with learning disabilities or ADHD face when they go into post-secondary?

There's quite a bit of feedback, saying that accessing accessibility services can be quite difficult. Let's say you have your assessment, you know you're going to need accommodations. There are a lot of hoops to jump through to get those accommodations. There's a lot of emails, a lot of forms. You have to fill out, a lot of things you have to do. We do actually have accessibility advisors on our network and we've given them that feedback. They're looking to see, you know, just to evaluate their own processes in terms of, you know, you're trying to make something accessible, but if your access to that is already not very accessible or not very friendly, I mean, what does that say for the rest of your experience then? Accessibility services can be difficult. And again, they generally don't have their parents to help transition them. Another barrier is that a lot of the strategies that might have worked in high school aren't necessarily going to work in a post-secondary environment. The classes are much larger, you know, the lectures are much longer. If you have ADHD, you cannot sit through a three-hour lecture. It's going to be impossible. The way you have to schedule your calendar, that's something students also don't have to do in high school. You pick your courses and you get your schedule, whereas in university you have to try and arrange those schedules yourself based on what classes are available. Again, if you have a learning disability, it will take you longer to do all your classes. You're not going to be able to take a full load like a full or being, let's say five courses. You know, you're going to be looking at three or four. That also means you're going to be spending more years at university. You know, from your own experience with ADHD that, you know, if someone especially

is has real struggles with organizational skills, that post-secondary is going to be really difficult.

There's quite a high rate of dropping out or dropping courses because they can't keep up because they're not they don't have good structures in place for, you know, when they need to study, when they need to attend classes, you know, doing activities for group work, everything that has to do with organization can be that much more difficult. It works well if there's a buddy system in place, but that's not always available either, right? Or, if long projects are cut down or broken down into smaller chunks. But not all professors do that. Some just say this is your deadline end of story. And so then you have to fight your own deadlines. Not everyone knows, one that they should do that. Or even if they do, then they find it really difficult to stick to it. Just going to university can take more years, which also makes it more expensive. And you still need a good support network while you're at post-secondary. And that support network, you basically have to create yourself then and that can be very difficult to do, especially if someone else is trying to hold down a job, a part time job at the same time. God forbid, they already have a family and they're trying to manage the family and going to post-secondary.

Anything that would already be on a higher level of complexity for anybody else if they also have a learning disability or ADHD that just ramps up that complexity to the point where it's either going to take you much longer or people drop out and because they can't deal with it. One of the other really big ones at university is that students that have accommodations have to go to the professor and talk to them about it.

That very rarely happens in high school. Students don't have that practice and so a lot of them actually don't go. They do have their accommodations, but just the fact that they have to talk to the press about it is overwhelming for them. And so they don't so they don't actually end up getting those accommodations that they have a right to and that have been approved or they go the day before the exam or something.

And that doesn't give the professor any time to prepare whatever he needs to prepare. She needs to prepare. You know, again, being an independent adult, when kids are 18, they're not really adults in that sense. In that sense. Right. it can be really difficult for them at post-secondary also, the professors are bound by law to provide accommodations, and that's not how it is in high school.

I do know that there are students out there who've been quite reluctant to approach the professors for accommodations because they think they're not really going to get it anyway because it didn't always happen consistently in high school. Their past experience in high school does carry over to their post-secondary as well. In terms of some of the assumptions they're making.

And of course, again, not every professor or instructor knows what a learning disability or ADHD is either. They're not always this happy about finding accommodations, right. They think someone is just going to have an easier time of it than someone else, and that's not helpful at all. I would also say that mental health services are becoming increasingly important at post-secondary level and they're not always great.

The mental health piece is really important and it's not always available. I'm just going to get used. On the other thing we've heard too is a post-secondary. Sometimes profs use different platforms for their courses and there you have to submit your work. That would be different because

someone would have to manage and juggle multiple different kinds of platforms because so again, there's a real pressure on the organizational and someone's organizational skills that wouldn't have been there in high school where the whole school division uses the same platform.

So that can be a real problem too. And I think the other thing that's come up is socially, if you're taking fewer courses because everything takes you longer to do, there's often less of an opportunity to engage in campus life, right, to join clubs or any of those sorts of things, and that certainly is still a really big part of a post-secondary experience.

Still that development of social skills and social networks and that can often suffer, too, just because there's so much more time that has to be dedicated to the actual studying and keeping yourself organized. I think that was the case. I'm sure more, but those are sort of the big ones that have come up. Yeah.

What is the biggest factor that you have seen for people with learning disabilities and ADHD deciding not to go to post-secondary?

I would say the biggest one is deciding they're not smart enough and financial the financial barriers. And one of the other reason that comes into it is that for a lot of post-secondary, in order to get accommodations, you have to have a current cycle, an assessment confirming your diagnosis. And that means for some for a lot of students, that they have to get a new one.

In high school, as long as you had one by grade ten, that will get you through all of high school. But if it needs to be only got three years old, that isn't necessarily valid anymore for post-secondary. Now some post-secondary have waived that. For example, state as long as you had a psych ed assessment affirming that you have learning, disability, ADHD, even if it's five years old, they'll still accept that you don't have to get a new one.

I'm pretty sure for and for you and for you, Calgary, you do need a more recent one. That means you have to pay for it even if you get some support, it still is still very expensive to get that done in order to get your accommodations. So, that can be another one of the financial barriers.

How does the LD & ADHD network support people with learning disabilities when attending post-secondary education.

In whatever way possible. The network is actually right now, we've teamed up with University of Calgary and they're producing an online course, a transition course for high school students to transition into post-secondary so that they can learn about all those things that are going to be different and practice those skills. And just this summer, they've added a game aspect to it.

They're developing an app for it. So, so that's super exciting. That'll be available for all day. School students will do an online course when students are at post-secondary. As a resource navigator, I can certainly help them in terms of helping them to understand what their responsibilities are, how they can approach professors. Who do they need to talk to?

If they need help getting an assessment, where they can get an assessment, grant programs, things like that, if they need help with organizational skills, I can certainly help them. But we can also refer them to academic coaches, which is better than having a tutor because an academic coach will actually teach you strategies that

will help you through your whole life. In whatever way we can support them, we will.

What other types of supports are available for people with learning disabilities and ADHD when attending post-secondary institutions?

I think it's important to remember there's actually quite a lot of scholarships and bursaries and grants out there for people with disabilities. I know sometimes if you if you have a learning disability, you don't necessarily see yourself as disabled in the sense of someone in a wheelchair or physically disabled or something like that.

It's still a disability in the sense that it allows you to apply for that financial support, a lot of people aren't aware of that. There's also the disability tax credit that you get on your that you can apply for income tax. And that can be a huge benefit. Emotional stress information thing. Certainly, I think the financial piece is really big for most people with disabilities and ADHD counts.

Just the same for that as well. Also helping them to understand later when stage completed their career and get a job accommodations that are available in the workplace. So, they're not just at university. You can have workplace accommodations too. And how you advocate for those as well.

Do you think that there are financial barriers that exist for people with learning disabilities and ADHD?

Absolutely, partly one, because you need those psych assessments are expensive. Post-secondary will pretty much always take someone with a learning disability or ADHD longer to complete. That's a considerable expense there. Not just in terms of putting out more money towards your education, but also potentially entering the workforce later. Sort of a bit of a double whammy there in some in some respects, say if you need some accommodations, you might require extra software for.

For example, one needs speech to text software or something like that. I mean, a lot of platforms have it built in now, but not everybody does. If you need something specific, there might be an extra cost associated with that mental health supports. If someone requires a lot of mental health supports or they're on medication, those are all things that add up to extra expenses.

You don't want someone deciding whether they're going to need to eat or take their medication. You don't want that kind of trade-off. I do think in general, it's more expensive, mainly because it will take longer to complete that degree.

Is there anything else you'd like to add that we've not previously discussed?

I think just the biggest thing is that if everybody was more aware of what a learning disability is and what isn't, and the same with ADHD, when there wouldn't be such resistance to accommodations in school or university and it would just reduce barriers because there just would be more natural support, right?

We would have to worry about saying, "I have a learning disability and I need X, Y and Z". It wouldn't be a big deal, you know, if I had to say, "Hey, yeah, you know what? I'm dyslexic and this is what I need to do".

Key Takeaways

Self-Advocacy

One thing that I did not come across in my desk research that came up in this interview was the importance of self-advocacy. In high school, students may have had the support of their parents to do this for them, but this is often not the case in university. Students are often left to advocate for themselves in the university setting, such as setting up accommodations with their professors, accessing services, etc.

Time to Complete

Carola discusses how for most people with a learning disability or ADHD, it takes longer to complete their degrees. This prompted me to confirm this with academic research, such as Carroll (2020) in Chapter 1. Additionally, this prompted me to ask people how long it took to complete their degree in my fieldwork (Chapter 3). This was significant to my research, as it shows that many people with disabilities in post-secondary education face the extra costs associated with taking longer to complete their studies, such as additional fees that the university charges per semester of enrollment.

Mental Health

Carola discusses how mental health supports and medication are an additional barrier to people with disabilities. This was significant to my research, as it prompted me to ask participants in my fieldwork (Chapter 3) to describe their mental health while in school to confirm if this was a trend seen by participants. Additionally, it lead me to research further into the association between mental health and learning disabilities (see LDAOeng, 2015 in Chapter 1).

Financial Barriers

In this interview, Carola was asked about what financial barriers exist for people with disabilities, and a number of reasons were given. For starters, she discusses the extra costs associated with getting supports for people with learning disabilities or ADHD, such as psych assessments. Additionally, Tiltmann brought up that people with learning disabilities, for the most part, take a longer time to complete their degree, which results in extra costs. Next, she discusses the extra costs that can be associated with additional learning supports, such as softwares. Lastly, Tiltmann discusses that costs of medication that are needed to support certain learning disabilities or ADHD can be quite costly. These all show that there are additional costs associated with having a learning disability or ADHD. Some of these costs are off-set by grants, but this is not enough to cover all the additional expenses that are associated with having a learning disability or ADHD.

Resources Available

Tiltmann discusses that there are a number of scholarships and bursaries available to students with a learning disability for starters. Additionally, she states that there is the disability tax credit that many people don't know about.

Self-Confidence

Carola discusses how a person's self-image or self-confidence impacts their decision to attend post-secondary education. For example, she states, "a lot of kids with learning disabilities and ADHD don't feel particularly smart. They think they're too stupid to go on to post-secondary. That will mainly come from the school experience they've had, especially if they've been diagnosed late or not diagnosed at all. School can be quite difficult for them". This shows that how a person with a disability looks at themselves will impact their decision to go on to post-secondary education. This is influenced by a number of things, such as their difficulty with high school, or the messages they receive from their peers about their abilities. These factors impact how a person with a disability looks at themselves, having a negative impact on their self-confidence and could deter them away from going on to post-secondary.

Colleen Smereka

Disability Resource Facilitator at St. Francis Xavier University

What is your role?

Okay, so my current role is my title is Disability Resource Facilitator at the Tramble Centre at St. FX University, and I've only been in this role about a year and a half and my three areas that I focus in on, there are some other things, but my key are funding, assistive technology and alternate text for students with disabilities and mental health, depending on if they have a permanent disability. Now I know that's changing in post-secondary right now, too persistent and prolonged or temporary in the East, it's a little bit different. But yeah, that's what I do.

How do you support students with disabilities in that role?

There's federal funding through student loans for students to get access to different supports, equipment, and services. I work with any student who is registered with our office and has provided us documentation to try to get those services. Now, it's complicated because not everyone can get that funding. Students have to qualify for a student loan to get that funding. I also teach students such technology, so programs like Read & Write Gold, Kurzweil 3000, Livescribe pens, Glean, any of those technologies. Then to be able to use like text to speech students will need an alternative format or in large print depending on what their disabilities are. I support students to get access to those texts from publishers or whatever other sources I have access to.

How do high school marks and courses taken impact someone's ability to attend post-secondary education?

Depending on the person, I'm like, how old are they when they go to a post-secondary and be successful without being successful in high school, or what some people might deem successful, I suppose. I guess in my mind is a complicated question because it depends what kinds of other skills does the person have? Are they resilient? Advocating skills will matter when they go to post-secondary. In general, students have to have certain courses to get in to certain programs. So they're dead set on getting in a particular program, and they're not open minded in terms of taking different route to get where they want to go, they have to have certain courses to get in to programs. If you have a learning disability, potentially, maybe you don't do well in those courses or you haven't received the right support in high school to support you? I have a lot of students currently who tell me that they didn't get supports in high school and I had a student the other day when I was asking her about what she might need and getting her to talk about her functional limitations or the barriers that she was experiencing, she actually welled up because she felt overwhelmed by my questions because she had never gotten support in high school. I guess it just depends. I'll just look at me. I got diagnosed with a learning disability when I was 22. I graduated high school, and I went to post-secondary and I did 100% better in

post-secondary than I did in high school. I guess when I look at that situation, I think to myself, it's not 100% correlation. If you did well in high school, you're going to do well in university because my brother did well in high school and he doesn't have a learning disability and he slept his way through university the first-year university, and he failed out. I think it's a very complicated question. The other thing that sort of impacts that is what sort of other skills did the student develop along the way. If you think about University of Calgary, there are some programs if you don't have an 80% average, you can't get into the programs because they won't accept you. So there's so many things that can impact that. If you're not getting the support that you need in high school and I think it varies on the education that the that the teachers have that where are they trying to get you through. I think the other thing that really comes to mind is the fact that in high school right now, you can pass in an assignment at the end of the year, as long as they pass it in by the end of the year, then the teacher will mark it. But you can't do that in post-secondary. So that translates and I think that really can impact a student.

What kind of barriers to people with learning disabilities or ADHD faced before they go to post-secondary?

I feel like that's a very individualized question. In general, I do think that some people face even the whole idea of getting access and getting a diagnosis. We have a lot of students who are getting support before they when they're in high school and they don't have a diagnosis. So that can impact them. They're getting support, some support, probably not all the support they need or they not getting educated on their disability and what their disability is, how it impacts them, those kinds of things that can really impact students' ability to gain confidence to go to post-secondary. I think that if they're not getting support saying they might not get the grades. Some students, if they're not doing well in school, they might not be encouraged to go because that could be a barrier as well. Just seeing themselves like if you are a student who are not getting support and you might not see yourself as somebody who goes to post-secondary, I don't think a lot of people understand learning strategies and how they can support a student. If a student doesn't have those people in their lives or are not lucky enough to maybe go to a school like Foothills Academy or Calgary Academy or some one of those schools where a lot of the teachers are doing professional development all the time and getting those supports. Those students might not understand learning strategies, cause the research says that people with learning disabilities and ADHD, and obviously this is a generalization, don't naturally build up or have good learning strategies. If you're not working with somebody to help you develop them, that could be a barrier too.

What kind of barriers to people with learning disabilities or ADHD face when they're in post-secondary?

My first thought is, this can go towards my last answer as well, but attitudinal barriers I think is, huge, in post-secondary from just in general right now at St. FX we're doing a strategic plan and everything from your admission process, none of those things are really taken into consideration a student's learning disability from the beginning of the process. I think that attitudes in classrooms maybe some instructors in general won't let students record class lectures. There's a real challenge around that kind of thing. I think attitudes are a big one. I think that the knowledge about

what supports are where you need to go before you go to post-secondary and the work that you should do to research how to get the supports before you go, before you start, I think is a huge barrier to students because many students wait until they get to post-secondary before they try to seek out the services. Then there could be two or three months before they can get services. Sometimes as a student, if they don't have the proper documentation or didn't know they needed proper documentation, it could be a year because getting in to get a psychologist or psycho educational assessment could take a long time. There could be a full year before they get support that they need. I think those are some and just in general. I think even when you go to attitudinal barriers to students sometimes are we're worried about stigma and so they don't ask for the support they need because they don't want to. They don't want their friends to know where they want to leave class to write their tests. Those kinds of things could create barriers for students as well.

Do you think there are financial barriers that exist for people finding disabilities?

I definitely do. I think that a lot of times students who maybe have disabilities can't work or find it hard to do a full course load, so that can be an impact. If they're taking a full course load but they can't work or maybe they're not taking a full course load and to allow themselves to work, but then it's going to take them longer to graduate. For an example, I when I went to school, I took a reduced course load and went to two classes in the summertime. So, then I wasn't able to work. Then it could cost more money too. I know there's some the funding that I do can offset some of those costs. But in general, I do think there's other costs that need to be that are associated with having a disability and being in post-secondary that other people don't have to see. For example, some of this funding that I do doesn't offset medication costs. Some people only take medication when they're in a classroom environment where they have to focus more so that will cost them more money. I think that there's a lot of reasons why it would cost hard to get into all of them. But the answer to my question is yes.

What kind of resources are available for people with disabilities that are often underutilized?

I think that adaptive technology is high in abandonment. Students get it, but they don't they don't often stick with it. I think that some of that comes from, maybe they don't have the skills or sometimes you have to put a lot of extra work into like really digging into the details and being committed to some of the technology or the technology push some students out of their comfort zone. They just maybe find it easier to just stay where they're comfortable. I do think that students sometimes have access to those, but they don't utilize it. Over the long term, they might abandon it more quickly. I do think that sometimes students have access to or could access more learning strategies, support but don't use them or don't utilize them in a way that can benefit them long term. You have to look at your own behavior and change that behavior to really impact your schooling. I sometimes believe that student don't utilize that kind of resource. You could get funding for it, not all students can get funding for, but some students. I sometimes believe that students continue to go back to where they're comfortable and they don't utilize those services.

Is there anything you'd like to discuss that we've not previously discussed yet?

I think that one of the major barriers that I see, and I think it kind of relates to most students, but I feel like it impacts more of the students who have disabilities potentially, is that parents tend to or have had to for a lot of their students with disabilities really advocate for the student. That's a role that a lot of parents have taken on over the years. I think one of the big challenges when they end up in post-secondary is that they don't know how to advocate for themselves. I think that can create a real barrier. It's not even just advocating nowadays. It goes beyond that where parents do a lot of the things for the students. When you now have to go to talk to your instructor or keep track of your finances or go and talk to a funding person like me that the students really struggle to understand the full picture and it creates a barrier because the student often doesn't now have the language and haven't had to do those kinds of things or process that kind of kind of meeting or those tasks. It can create a barrier, and a lot of students do feel overwhelmed with that process because they haven't had to do those kinds of things before. I know a lot of the work that I do, I don't meet with student, and I try to communicate more with the student because I want to educate them on how to do it because it's also a life skill that they have to take into the world. I find that the work I'm doing sometimes does create barriers for students, because in general, our process is also set up for meetings and some students with ADHD, have a hard time keeping track of papers, organization, so all that can create a barrier that I think we don't really think about very often.

Key Takeaways

Self-Confidence

A common trend that both Carola and Colleen talked about was the idea of self-confidence. For example, Colleen states, “They’re getting support, some support, probably not all the support they need or they not getting educated on their disability and what their disability is, how it impacts them, those kinds of things that can really impact students’ ability to gain confidence to go to post-secondary”. Some people with a disability do not see themselves as someone that goes on to post-secondary because of this, which can impact their decision to go to post-secondary education.

Self-Advocacy

Similar to Carola, Colleen discusses how when a person with a disability transitions from high school to post-secondary, they are often faced with the challenge of advocating for themselves, which may not be skills they developed in high school, depending on how involved their parent or guardian was in this process. For some, their parents did this for them and as a result, the individual did not have the chance to build these skills for themselves. Once they reach post-secondary, when they are left to do this advocating on their own, they have to start from scratch in building these skills, which can be a learning curve.

Resources Available

Colleen provides 3 primary resources to students: funding, assistive technology and alternate text. The funding comes from the federal grant for students with disabilities. Assistive technology includes things like Livescribe pens, which help students take notes and record lectures. These resources are some of many that Smereka provides to students. When asked what resources are often underutilized, Colleen states that adaptive technology has a high abandonment rate, suggesting that students may feel out of their comfort zone when using this technology.

Building Learning Strategies

Smereka discusses the importance of building learning strategies for people with disabilities stating, “research says that people with learning disabilities and ADHD, and obviously this is a generalization, don’t naturally build up or have good learning strategies. If you’re not working with somebody to help you develop them, that could be a barrier too”. This shows the importance of teaching people with learning disabilities or ADHD learning strategies to use in their post-secondary education.

Lauren Goegan

Ph.D. - Assistant Professor at University of Manitoba

What is your role?

I'm an assistant professor at the University of Manitoba.

What is your research background?

So my research looks at the transition from high school to post-secondary for students with learning disabilities. And I typically look at that from a motivation theory lens. I also dabble a little in the work of looking at what is academic success, looking beyond grades, and also looking at academic dishonesty, so plagiarism, a fun topic.

What are the biggest factors that impact a person with a learning disability in their transition from high school to post-secondary?

I think one of the things that's really challenging for individuals with learning disabilities is really just the amount of change all at once. It's a new environment, it's new classes, it's new expectations, and it can be a lot all at once for an individual with an LD and really knowing how to navigate that change, I think is really important for them. A lot of the times in the work that I do, they seem really understanding of that it's going to be change, but really that how to navigate it is really hard to know until you're actually at the university and having to like come up against a process who doesn't want to give you an accommodation or how to actually study for this different type of test, to write this different type of paper? And so I think really understanding that change to really having those supports in place, I think is sometimes a barrier because sometimes they don't even know that it's going to be a barrier. They've written their papers the same way in high school throughout all those years, and then it's a very different style of writing when they get to postsecondary. How do you write that academic paper and how it's not that 5 paragraph paper with the introduction, three paragraphs and your conclusion, you can't write that really at university depending on the course. So really just navigating those situations, how to get accommodations is also really challenging. So knowing that you have to have an accommodation letter depending on where you're going and perhaps have to sign off on that, they have to provide you with those accommodations and then what happens if it doesn't work can also be really challenging. And these are adults now as they move into that post-secondary space. So like mom and dad are in theory not involved, but at least less involved in helping you get those accommodations so really being able to advocate for yourself and getting the support, I think can be a challenge, particularly as you've gone to a school where everybody knows you and they're used to the accommodations you need and working those into their classroom. These profs don't know you and oftentimes it can be quite large classes, so it's hard to maybe navigate that expectation, how to get those things that you need. So those can be challenges I see for students.

How do high school marks and courses taken impact someone's ability to attend post-secondary education?

Yeah, I don't like that question. I don't like grades. I mean, grades and stuff do have to impact it. I'm not a big fan of grades because there's so much difficulty in assigning the grades and what do grades mean. Then if you curve grades and all those kinds of spaces there, grades are not my favorite thing, but they do have a role because there are going to be cutoffs to get into certain types of programs. So grades are going to have that role. I understand universities need to have some sort of cut off. It's too hard to look at all the different applicants for different programs. You have hundreds and hundreds and thousands of applicants depending on the program, and there's got to be some sort of quantitative measure to just kind of make a line. But that's a really hard space, I think, for students and so grades do impact getting into that post-secondary space as much as I don't want them to. But I mean, it's important when I would talk to students about grades, keeping in mind that once you're out of post-secondary, I mean, if you're in the career, you want, no one's going to go back and ask you like what was what was your grade in grade 11 English ,Right. Like no one is asking you those questions. So it's really making sure you're learning what you need to get the information out of your courses and then be successful in the career that you've chosen. So I don't like grades, but I understand why they're there, and I'm sure you're not a fan of grades either.

What types of barriers do people with learning disabilities or ADHD face before they go to post-secondary?

So in high school I can didn't really it's going to depend on the student and the learning challenges that they're going to have. So they may have difficulties and now the most common accommodation is going to be extended time. So on exams, making sure they've got the space to have the time they need to be able to read the questions as being asked of them and being able to provide their answers. Extended time is also a very difficult accommodation to get at post-secondary, particularly if they want double time. That's a hard one. Most universities don't like to give students that much extra time for whatever reason, and making sure they've got the time to kind of work through their answers when it comes to that kind of thing. Finding note takers can be really difficult on learning how to take notes. It's not really a skill we really teach you kind of that they're going to learn as they go. But it's it is a skill that sometimes requires a bit of extra learning in that kind of space, how to study effectively. It's not just reading and memorizing. It's really kind of learning the material in a way, flashcards can really help kind of thinking about the material in different way, creating study groups and those can be really helpful spaces for kiddos without the ADHD breaking down tasks is also a really good strategy, but oftentimes it's a power through those cram sessions right before an exam or not effective. So kind of breaking down the tasks that need to be done is really helpful strategy. But sometimes we don't do that for various reasons. All the things we've got going on in our lives for sure can be a challenge. There. And then again, it's going to depend on the student. If they have difficulties with working memory attention of the different spaces, it's going to impact the strategies only in the end the barriers that they're going to experience.

What types of barriers do people with learning disabilities or ADHD face while they're in post-secondary?

So those are the barriers one will be getting accommodations. So one of the challenges is having making sure your school is up to date. And that's one thing I think students sometimes forget because it's so focused on getting from high school to secondary that they kind of forget about the paperwork along the way. So making sure they're secured is up to date because if it's not, then they can't get access to accommodations and it can kind of slow things down and it can be a barrier, particularly if students have to pay out of pocket for it. Sometimes it can be covered by, you know, medical insurance that you have for your parent folks with yourself, whatever it is. But that's one thing to keep in mind as well, those kind of secured assessments. There's one: a profs understanding of learning disabilities. I think that depending on the faculty that they're in, we know certain faculties are less understanding just because of sometimes less knowledge on what is a learning disability. There's a lot of education in that K-12 setting, but not so much in maybe something like engineering, depending on the faculty, there can be different levels of knowledge. So understanding why accommodations are important and how to incorporate them into courses, particularly when it's a cohort, sometimes one of the accommodations that's required is a reduced course load. So when you have a program that's very much like you have to take these courses in the fall and these courses in the winter, I mean, to navigate breaking that down into maybe three and three and what happens to those additional courses at the end of the day can be really difficult as well, depending on faculty needs and the structure of the program.

Do you think that financial barriers exist for people with learning disabilities?

Yes, the psychoed report is it can be costly. It can cost anywhere from being like $2,000. I've heard like almost $5,000 to get a new psyched assessment done, which can be really challenging because as we know, learning disabilities are lifelong, so sometimes depending on why that paperwork is required can create a hurdle and a challenge for these individuals depending on if they are taking a reduced course load, there is going to be the financial challenge of having to pay for additional semesters because of your learning needs. If you can't take five courses at once and you have to take three or four to even, you're going to take longer in your program and it's going to cost extra because you have to pay for all those additional elements in education, those student fees and all those kinds of spaces that I sometimes feel like programs should be based have a cost attached to them rather than term by term, particularly if you're not accessing some of the services. I think of the UPass. I went to the U of C and I know I had to drive in and I wanted to pay for the pass and that one always made me angry. Those things are expensive. And then if you don't get funding for some accommodations like assistive tech, that can be really expensive. So things like Dragon and Kurzweil. I know Kurzweil to set up is like a couple thousand dollars to get. If you don't meet the guidelines, the funding, then you had to pay out of pocket for those types of programs. And then there's like text help as well that costs some money. But I mean, all tech does. But if you don't get those accommodations, then let them get funding, then they have to pay for them out of pocket, which can cause another financial burden for them in that space. And then also like tutoring and stuff, if they don't get qualify for having those covered,

getting a tutor or a strategist or those types of individuals can really cause a challenge as well.

Is there anything else you would like to add that we have not previously discussed?

I think it really comes from a place of trying to understand this change in this new environment, and so it's really hard to know. The first semester is always the hardest because you're kind of thrown into it and trying to figure out like now what you thought about it, but have you ever actually been to the campus? Then COVID, that's made it especially difficult to navigate getting to campus and having those conversations with maybe disability service providers. Getting in early is really important in navigating the spaces. So I always like to recommend to students take a reduced course of that first term until you've kind of understood the situation, how to access all your things, how are things going with profs, where your classes are and then, if you're feeling good with a reduced course load, then add more after, I always find thats a helpful strategy.

Key Takeaways

Self-Advocacy

Like the interviews with Colleen and Carola, the topic of self-advocacy came up in this interview. This shows that it is clearly an important part of my research project, and an idea that did not come up in my primary research.

Grades

Dr. Goegan discusses how grades should ideally not have such an impact on a person's ability to attend post-secondary in her ideal world, but the sad reality is that this is a huge barrier for people with disabilities from entering a post-secondary program. Lauren also stresses that people should not care too much about their grades as once they are in their careers, their grades won't matter too much.

Access to Accommodations

Like previous interviews, Dr. Goegan discusses how accessing accommodations can be a barrier in and of itself. First, there is a large cost associated with getting a psychoeducational assessment completed. Additionally, professors may not properly implement their accommodations once they do finally get them, so that creates an additional barrier for the student in getting support to have their accommodations implemented.

Financial Barriers

As previously mentioned, psychoeducational assessments can be very costly if required to get accommodations. Additional costs that were brought up include: note takers, softwares, and fees that are associated with taking longer to complete a degree.

Preparedness for University

Dr. Goegan discusses how often times when people with disabilities reach post-secondary, they do not feel properly prepared for this transition. Dr. Goegan suggests that people with learning disabilities start off with a reduced course load and increase it if/when they feel ready to do so. Additionally, Dr. Goegan brings up that people need to relearn how to write an essay once they reach post-secondary, as the 5 paragraph method that is taught in high schools often does not apply to post-secondary papers.

Faculty Differences

Dr. Goegan states that some faculties may be better equipped than other faculties to implement accommodations, which can be an additional barrier for people with disabilities in the programs that are less equipped for this. As there is no standardized way of implementing accommodations, it is often up to the professor to decide how to do so.

Chapter 3

Fieldwork

Collection of Fieldwork

I connected with 6 people that had expressed interest in participating in interviews that had a diagnosed learning disability. These individuals come from a range of academic backgrounds, including people who have completed their degrees and people who dropped out of school. Having a range of people helps me to better understand the issues and factors at play that made their university experience more challenging.

Each person was asked the same series of questions to get a variety of different ideas for the various topics. In the following pages, the questions and responses are provided.

Participants were asked to provide consent to use their responses for the purpose of this project (See Figure 1).

The reason that I chose to do interviews for my fieldwork was to ensure that I was not letting my personal experiences as a person with a learning disability completely influence my findings. Although my experiences give me insight into the issues at hand, I wanted to make sure that these experiences were similar with other people with learning disabilities. The questions were curated as a result of the interview with Carola Tiltmann (Chapter 2), who mentions mental health, financial barriers, personal barriers such as self-confidence, and low high school grades.

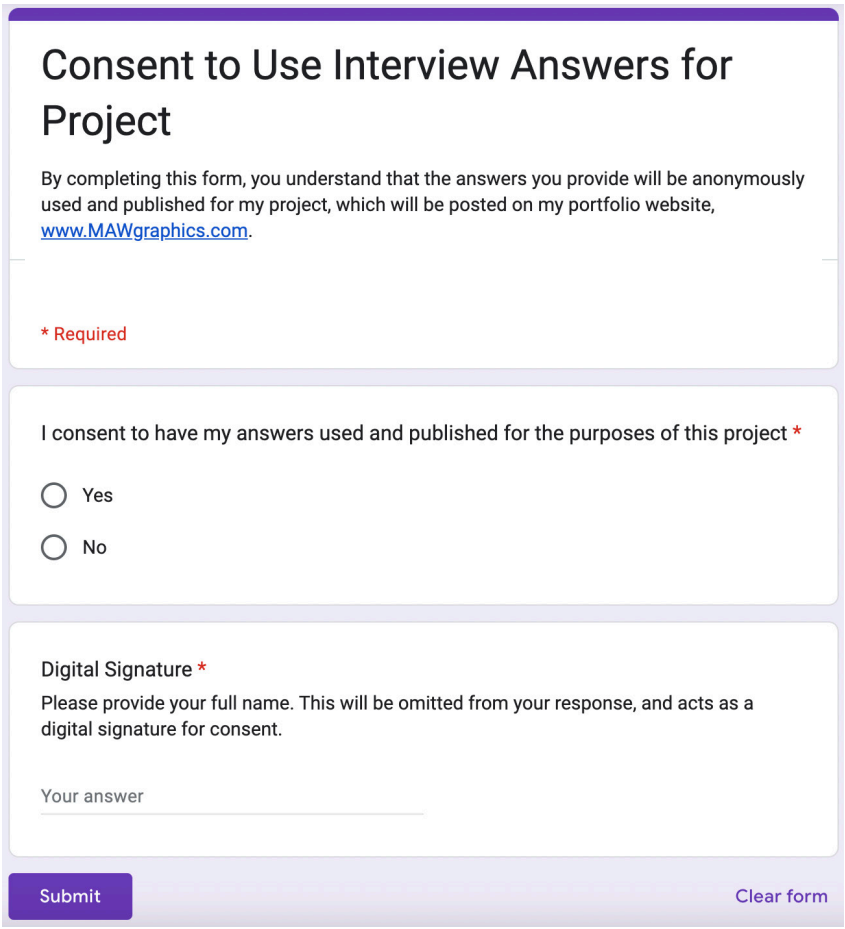


Figure 1: Consent for sent to participants of the fieldwork to use their responses for this project.

Ethics Considerations

As per Article 2.2 of the TCPS 2 (2018) guidelines, Public domain with no expectation of privacy, ethics approval is not required for interviews that are published on the web. As such, participants were requested to consent to having their interview responses posted online with their name removed from the post.

Article 4.6 of the TCPS 2 (2018) guidelines state, “individuals with cognitive impairments or intellectual disabilities, may lack the capacity to decide whether to participate in particular research initiatives”. Taking this into consideration, people were selected to interview that could provide informed consent for the purposes of this study.



PANEL ON RESEARCH ETHICS

Navigating the ethics of human research

TCPS 2: CORE

Certificate of Completion

This document certifies that

Mitch Wilson

has completed the Tri-Council Policy Statement:
Ethical Conduct for Research Involving Humans
Course on Research Ethics (TCPS 2: CORE)

Certificate # 0000542940

Date of Issue: **15 September, 2019**

Figure 2: TCPS 2: Core Ethics Certificate

Interview Questions and Responses

What type of learning disabilities do you have?

P1: I have ADHD.

P2: I have ADHD and ADD, and I am pretty sure I am an undiagnosed dyslexic.

P3: I have ADHD.

P4: I have ADHD, if that counts.

P5: I'm dyslexic and I have ADHD.

P6: I have ADHD.

What was your overall experience of post-secondary education?

P1: My experience with post secondary education was overall good, but I found the structure to be too rigid.

P2: It's been very stressful and hard to navigate. Coming into my first 2 years of university, I struggled a lot to understand information and grasp concepts that were being taught. It was really hard for me to understand certain instructional guides, project descriptions, etc. I really struggled around testing and test anxiety, and just being very overwhelmed with the amount of work and how to manage it, while being distracted very easily.

P3: I had a hard time focusing in class and found it difficult to manage my time to complete assignments.

P4: I didn't know that there were any resources for me, it was never talked about or told to me until my 3rd year of university. I didn't even know there were grants available for me, or that I could write an exam in a different room. I had no idea that there was anything available at all.

P5: I would say just education in general for me was quite stressful, especially being dyslexic as well, because I feel like a lot of teachers just didn't believe me growing up. And then when I went into university, I found it hard because I went to a university where one of my classes had 240 people in it. So there's no asking for help or getting help and if you get distracted, you're just on your own. I always found that I didn't do well in the large classes, because I would get distracted very easily, and I would start paying attention to everyone else's screens except for my own. And then I can't listen and look at things.

P6: Overall, good. However, I have definitely found that as I've gotten older, I've struggled more with like the negative aspects of ADHD and related to my learning.

How would you describe your mental health during post secondary?

P1: The worst it has ever been. I am still depressed, but since graduating, I am not nearly as stressed out and suicidal and having as many panic attacks.

P2: It's been quite bad, lots of stress, strain and struggle, feeling very confused and vulnerable to the fact that I don't know what's happening, and I feel like I know

a lot less about what's happening than others. I feel like I am not doing the work to the best of my ability like others are able to.

P3: During post-secondary, my depression got significantly worse. I struggled a lot with my anxiety, which impacted my ability to make friends in university.

P4: I would say it was less than par, it was not great. I had a lot of things going on at once, and I didn't have any resources available to utilize, so I was overwhelmed often.

P5: I was very depressed, extremely depressed. Extremely anxious. I did not take care of myself in any form. I was just constantly stress and depressed.

P6: Generally, not the best. As much as that is attributed to, you know, stuff going on outside of school, like just, you know, my personal life. However, I think sometimes the stress of school and like what compounds that, yeah. I'm doing better now, though.

Did you or do you plan on completing your post-secondary education?

P1: Yes, I graduated from my degree.

P2: Yes, this year I will be finished.

P3: I dropped out halfway through my second year of a 3-year program, so about half-way through my studies.

P4: I finished my degree.

P5: I am not completing what I previously started, but I start post-secondary again in November, actually. I'm doing it online this time on my own pace, not in a large classroom.

P6: I do plan on finishing my bachelor's degree. I am undecided about continuing on after that.

Did you finish your degree in the "normal" amount of time (OR) Are you on track to graduate on time, or will you need extra time?

P1: Yeah, I took 4 years to complete my degree. However, I did 3 electives while upgrading, which helped reduce my course load once I got into the program. I also took 2 courses in the spring semesters to help reduce my course load.

P2: I will be graduating on time, one of my biggest problems when it comes to school is actually being critical and hard on myself, having really high expectations that I feel the need to complete in the 4 years. I took spring and summer classes for 2.5 years to help me get to this point, some of which was while I was in a work term.

P3: I did not complete myy studies.

P4: No, I took an additional year to complete my degree.

P5: Yeah, I will need extra time. Just now. I'm working full time. It'll be very weird going back after not doing it for a long time. I mean, I feel like I haven't practiced a lot of skills that will help me focus so I don't feel in the first semester it's going to be hard.

P6: I am in my extra time, just one semester. Hopefully, everything goes well. If everything goes according to plan.

Did you have accommodations in your post-secondary education?

P1: No, I got diagnosed in my last year, and I decided it was not worth getting special testing done for one more year.

P2: I didn't know I was eligible for accommodations until the end of my 3rd year of university, where I found out that ADHD/ADD, were worthy of getting accommodations. Even my doctor didn't know that ADHD would qualify as a learning disability in school, and I could get accommodations for such disorders.

P3: No, at the time of attending post-secondary education, I was not yet diagnosed with ADHD, so I was not eligible to receive accommodations.

P4: Yeah, in my 3rd year and onward, I had accommodations.

P5: No. But, I've never I never asked for them either. I've never been someone who did. I guess my own fault I didn't go out of my way to ask, but fair enough. I watched other people do it and I was like, it didn't seem super attainable. And I just I always really had the mindset that I wasn't severe enough to ask for help.

P6: I have, but I haven't really been able to utilize them as much because our program is more project based. I feel like of them are more relevant for courses that where there are like frequent lectures, note taking and tests. Even though I've had them, they haven't really used them outside of like one semester. Also, I wasn't diagnosed until I was about to start my third year. I didn't even know, I didn't even have access to accommodations until halfway through my degree.

What kind of barriers did you experience in your post-secondary education as a result of your learning disabilities?

P1: I always found I struggled to comprehend exams, it wasn't that I wasn't understanding the information in class, I just don't test well with having ADHD. So that was a huge barrier, exams would usually bring my marks down quite a bit. I also found with some professors, the lack of flexibility made it difficult to juggle a work-school balance, and obviously as a university student you don't make a lot of money, I think that added to the stress, but I would always choose work over assignments if I needed to.

P2: I take a long time to process information, especially on tests, given that I have such high test anxiety. Going into the tests, I am already extremely nervous. Then when I get into test situations, and I am under time, I struggle to read for comprehension, and tend to read what's given to me and not comprehend what the questions are actually asking. I struggle to finish either on time, or I finish too quickly, because I feel rushed, and I feel like I need to get in and out as quick as I can, despite my knowledge on the topic, I do quite poorly on tests, and it is primarily because of my test anxiety that my grades suffer.

P3: I had a lack of emotional supports through my education. I had a hard time sitting down and studying and listening to lectures for 3 hours straight, I would get easily distracted, as I can not sit down for long periods of time. I also had a hard time taking notes in class, which impacted my ability to study.

P4: I got distracted easily, taking notes was really difficult because sometimes I would zone out and then miss a portion of what we had to have written down. That was a big thing because when I would look back at my notes, I would have all these blank parts that I didn't know what they were. When I had to write tests in class, I found it very distracting when people would be ruffling their papers, or tapping, or making noises, drinking water, I found that very difficult. Also, managing my time, I had to work really hard on.

P5: I did very poorly in post-secondary. I yeah, I procrastinated a lot, which definitely was my own fault. I did this thing where if I can't keep up in class and I can't keep up on my readings, I would just give up, I wouldn't care. I feel like probably a lot of it was my fault, but a lot of it just couldn't focus on anything and then mix with my depression and everything, which is why I dropped out. Even in the class I liked, one of my classes I was really passionate about that I really loved and I was not passing it and I was like, okay, if I had even passed the one class that I actually enjoy going, feel like, why am I here? My GPA was not thriving.

P6: I think it's a good question because when you first when you ask me that initially, I don't really think anything like that are like super obvious to me because I think because I didn't find out until so late, but I just kind of accepted it as like part of the university experience. I think time management has been obviously like very challenging for me, so having to make abrupt change is a challenge for me if I'm not given a lot of notice. Sometimes in courses that have group work, I've tried to handle it as best as I can, but sometimes I think that kind of will get to me.

Did your high school grades affect your ability to attend post-secondary education?

P1: Yes, I had to upgrade my English course to get into the program I wanted to get into.

P2: Sort of, I had a little bit of a unique circumstance surrounding my university entrance. I got sick in my grade 12 year and I had to teach myself all of my schooling at home. I had to learn all the material and go in and write tests. I wasn't accommodated whatsoever for any medical problems that were going on. I had to reach out to a few universities that I applied at to inform them of this, as my grades were not as good as my previous years.

P3: Yes, I applied to university and could not get in due to my grades, so I went to a college instead. I had to take a math class for my program, as I did not do math past grade 10.

P4: My high school grades were okay, I was like a B student.

P5: Yeah, I had to go into post-secondary as just an open student because I did apply for programs at other universities and other colleges but I did not get in. I had to go as undeclared to get into anything because it was so competitive and my grades just weren't there. I actually did okay, mostly through middle school, then once I got in the high school, I feel like that's just when I started my grades just started dropping so badly and then I just never really recovered.

P6: No, they did not. They did in that I had I had good grades in high school because I was able to figure out a way that worked for me in high school courses and transitioning to university. Our program is so much different in terms of like how you're taught, so I couldn't really translate a lot of that

Did you receive any financial support as a result of your disability?

P1: No - as I was not diagnosed with ADHD until my final year, I did not receive any grants.

P2: I received financial support as a result of my disability in my 3rd and 4th year of university after I found out that this was something that I was eligible for. Before that, I didn't know about any financial possibilities or any accommodations that surrounded any of my diagnosis as a university student specifically.

P3: No, this disability was not diagnosed at the time, so I funded my education through student loans.

P4: Like my accommodations, I had grants from my 3rd to 5th years.

P5: No. Again, I didn't ask for it. I didn't look into it or any of that. But I also didn't know that I had ADHD until I started university. I knew I was dyslexic, but with ADHD, I didn't realize that until I got into university that I had it and then started figuring it out from there. I feel like a lot of people don't find out until later.

P6: No. I didn't even know that I could apply for permanent disability until this semester, which is hilarious because I'm in fifth year. I have not received any financial support from my disability. I've received some support for other things.

Do you think there should be more financial support for people with disabilities accessing post-secondary education?

P1: Yes - having more financial support would help reduce the amount of work someone needs to do while in school, which would give them a better learning experience. This could potentially help reduce the amount of burnout that I experienced.

P2: I do, I think there also needs to be more awareness about it, because the only reason I knew I was eligible for accommodations was because my younger sister is coded and has lots of learning disabilities that have been addressed since she was a child. That's the only reason I knew I was eligible for these accommodations, was because she was eligible for them. If I did not have a sister that has already gone through all the hoops and steps to go through, I would've had no idea about it, and I wouldn't have been able to have had financial aid or accommodations that have helped me flourish a lot better in my university career.

P3: Yes - I think it is difficult enough for people with disabilities to manage their finances, let alone while trying to juggle a post-secondary course load. This would help alleviate some of the financial stress that people face when attending their schooling, and could help reduce the amount of time they spend in something like a part-time job, which would give them more time to focus on their studies, as it already takes us longer to complete assignments and study for exams.

P4: Yes - If you have a little bit more to put towards things like therapy, or get an advisor or specialist to work with you, it would make it a lot easier for people to manage their coursework.

P5: I think so, yeah. I feel like we're deterred a lot from going back to school. I know it's taken me quite a few years to decide to go back. Even if it's not financial, I feel like there should be better resources. I feel if you have to go through so many hoops and get properly diagnosed, which costs money and takes so much time in order for people to actually take you seriously. I feel like there should be other ways, we shouldn't have to prove ourselves that we're struggling. I don't think it hurts to have little bit more financial help. So, yeah, why not?

P6: I don't know the extent of what is already out there so much because I haven't had a knowledge to go and look further to access it. I think reducing barriers to postsecondary education in whatever ways possible, which I don't think has any negative consequences or implications. So yeah, I do think that more financial support would be good.

Key Takeaways

Financial Literacy

Many participants did not know about the existing financial supports that are in place for people with learning disabilities. As such, many of them did not access them in their studies. This shows that there is a lack of knowledge for people with learning disabilities in accessing financial supports to help fund their schooling. Additionally, a participant mentioned that when forced to, they would choose their job over their schooling due to their own poor financial planning, which is a common problem for people with learning disabilities, especially ADHD.

Exams

Participants 1, 2 and 4 expressed challenges with tests and examinations. This can be for a number of reasons, such as needing more time writing exams, or getting distracted by their surroundings. Many of these types of issues can be mitigated with accommodations, but as the next section suggests, many people have problems accessing accommodations.

Access to Accommodations

Many participants state that they; did not use their accommodations, did not bother applying for accommodations, or were not eligible for accommodations due to a late diagnosis. These show that there is a huge barrier in accessing accommodations in post-secondary institutions. This echoes some of the literature that is out there. For example, Gyenes et al. (2014) suggests the needs for standardized means of providing documentation for their disability.

Late Diagnosis

Many participants state that they did not receive a formal diagnosis until later in their degrees. As such, they were not eligible for accommodations and were forces to struggle their way through their classes until they got a diagnosis. This is one of the problems that arises with accommodation-based accessibility practices. If someone does not have a formal diagnosis, they do not get access to the services they need to help them succeed in their studies. This also shows the importance of how Universal Design for Learning (UDL) can help mitigate some of these barriers for people with undiagnosed disabilities.

Grades

Participants noted that their grades in high school were impacted as a result of their learning disability and as a result, impacted their ability to get into programs in post-secondary. For some, they had to upgrade courses before getting into a program. For others, they had to apply to things like open studies or undeclared major to be accepted.

Note Taking

Participants 3 and 4 expressed that they had a difficult time taking notes in class as they would get easily distracted. As a result, this would impact their ability to study for tests and exams.

Mental Health

Most participants state that their mental health suffered severely while in post-secondary education. This shows that there is a lack of mental health resources available to people with disabilities, or a lack of financial resources available to access these services.

Time to Complete Degree

Of the people interviewed that did not drop out, most of them stated that they needed extra time to complete their program. The only participant that stated they did not need extra time to complete their degree said that they took spring and summer courses to reduce their course load during the school year in order to complete their degree in 4 years.

Frustration

Participants found that they were frustrated with all the hoops that they had to jump through in order to get accommodations. One participant expressed that even with their accommodations, it did not benefit them for the most part based off how their program is set up. Additionally, many participants were not diagnosed with their learning disability until later in life, which subjected them to suffering in silence for many years without the supports in place to better suit their learning needs.

Financial Support

When asked, all participants agreed that there should be more financial supports in place for people with a learning disability. However, when asked why, their answers varied. Some stated that they found a hard time balancing work and school, so having extra funding would help alleviate the amount of work they required to get by, to give them the extra time to focus on their studies, as people with disabilities require more time to learn. Others discussed the extra costs associated with having a learning disability, such as assessments, medication and more.